described by Shashi Tharoor as ‘Nehru’s grand international pretensions’ being cut down to size.[19]

Inevitably, this fusion of the personal and the political often skewed perceptions, lending credence to the belief in certain quarters that moral grandstanding aside, this stoking of the Prime Minister’s vanity was indeed the primary goal of Indian foreign policy – an opinion exemplified by the scathing remarks of the then American vice-president, Richard Nixon, in 1954: ‘Mr Nehru does not like the United States, Great Britain, Communist China or the USSR; he only likes Mr Nehru, and India.’[20]

All of the above-mentioned factors contributed to making Nehru the undisputed czar of India’s foreign – and by extension defence – policies. To quote the political commentator Inder Malhotra, he was ‘its inventor, interpreter and executor’.[21] These factors also ensured that the moral concerns and presuppositions, in the words of the scholar Paul F. Power, ‘of a complex and remarkable man prevailed over a wide spectrum of diplomatic, ideological and strategic considerations’.[22] These concerns and presuppositions, and the policies they engendered – such as the ‘Panchsheel’ doctrine[23] for example – collectively came to comprise the ‘Nehruvian consensus’.

The extraordinary life of this foreign policy consensus, its intellectual and institutional architecture only partially dismantled in 1962 has, however, obscured its heavily contested origins. Three views dominate common perception – first, that Nehru remained unchallenged in the foreign policy domain, allowing no alternative paradigms to be put forward,[24] second that this was due to a paucity of colleagues who could inform foreign policy[25] and third, that the flaws in Nehru’s approach and resultant criticism of it only became visible after Sino-Indian clashes first erupted in the bleak Himalayan heights in 1959.[26] All are far from the truth.

Much before it became a consensus, Nehruvian foreign policy constituted a decisive fault line within democratic India’s first Cabinet, and a vital point of contention between the Prime Minister and his deputy, Sardar Patel. Few realize how perilously close the consensus came to falling apart in its